

Hard drives

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Hard drives have gone through yet another refresh with capacities doubling and prices plummeting. With Blu-ray writers and media still out of reach, hard drives are still the solution a lot of us go with when it comes to taking backups. My friends have been bugging me to find some good quotes on drives as well. So I decided it was time to go hunting for some drives.

Street shopping's the way

Now hard drives aren't something you expect to find neatly stacked in shelves when you walk into a large mall. The faithful Lamington road or your local computer hardware street is where you should land up first. I made my way to a few local shops to start my investigations. I was clear about what I wanted - I was looking for internal hard drives for my desktop and also my laptop.

Most of my friends wanted large capacity drives for storing movies and games installations. They are non-believers in DVDs and drives are the way to go according to them. I started asking around at shops for 1.5 and 2 TB drives. The drive market in India is dominated by Seagate and Western Digital. Its been done to make things simpler for the customer but brands have tried to categorise drives into performance and reliability. WD's Green drives seemed like the ideal line of drives for those who want a secondary drive on their drive to dump data on. Some of my friends even had plans to dump the data on the drive and keeping it aside. When I asked for prices, I was surprised to see 2 TB prices down to Rs. 6,400. When drives in excess of 1 TB started becoming a common sight in the market, 1.5 TB and 2 TB drives were still beyond the reach of many.

Now, 1 TB is a bare minimum anyone should go for. It also happens to be the

best value-for-money capacity. The price of a one terabyte 7200.12 series drive from Seagate for example is just Rs. 3,400. For most of us, this should suffice for games and other media such as movies, music and photos. A WD Caviar Green drive of the 1.5 TB capacity costs Rs. 5,000. Prices are competitive. There was only a difference of Rs. 100 - Rs. 150 between the WD Green series 1.5 TB and Seagate 7200.12 1.5 TB, with the Seagate being the cheaper of the two.

When budget is important

There were a few requests for the cheapest SATA drives available. The Seagate 250GB drives were well under Rs. 1,750. These are good for those setting up many cheap systems for offices and cybercafes. There are even some IDE drives available in the market. Don't consider them, but those using even older systems buy these. I could only find drives starting from 80 GB to 250 GB from Seagate and Samsung. Prices are a lot higher though. If a SATA WD 250 GB costs Rs. 1,750, then an IDE drive would be Rs. 3,000 or so. Maxtor, (for those who don't know), isn't available anymore and Hitachi isn't pushed by vendors.

I had to ask for the price of the the WD Velociraptor. It was a little more difficult to find than the other drives. It's a performance drive but the price is a little difficult to digest. After much difficulty, I found the drive for Rs. 13,000 for the older 300 GB version.

SSDs are slowly entering the market but they're still not mainstream. They're cooler than standard hard drives but they are way more expensive. For the price of two, 2-terabyte drives, you could buy one 64 GB SSD. For most people, it's hard to justify the cost. Kingston and Intel SSDs are the ones I saw. Intel's old 80GB SSD



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was priced at Rs. 15,400. When I asked the shopkeepers, they didn't really seem very interested in selling these products. Only some shops had

these drives and these were normally the shops enthusiasts and gamers would go to buy hardware. Some of the shops imported a few models from some brands. We found SSDs from brands like Corsair and G.Skill. Prices were more or less similar. There were also some brands called Solidata. They had a 64GB model priced at just Rs. 9,900 which was a lot less than the other brands. Most of the SSDs were of the 2.5-inch format and there are converters available to make the 2.5-inch drive fit into a 3.5-inch bay. Price for this attachment is Rs. 800.

Laptop hard drives are also getting popular. Replacing laptop hard drives isn't complicated anymore. People with laptops running on small 80GB drives can now upgrade to 320, 500 GB and these days even 750 GB drives. We see quite of these drives from Seagate and WD in the test centre. I looked around for the largest laptop 2.5-inch SATA drive. The shopkeeper told me that a Seagate one would cost Rs. 3,200 - not too bad for a large capacity drive. IDE drives of the same capacity will be around twice the price of SATA drives. 750 GB drives were not to be found but we should see them in the next month or so.

I decided to pick up a Caviar 1.5 TB for the HTPC and compiled a list to mail my friends from my cell phone while I left Lamington Road. It was pleasing to see drives at such low prices and the possibility of setting up a RAID array using fast drives was exciting.

One thing's for sure, if you're looking to buy drives, there couldn't be a better time. If you were thinking SSDs instead of hard drives, you'll have to wait for now. 